

Gigabyte EP45-DS4P

Gigabyte joins in on the P45 race

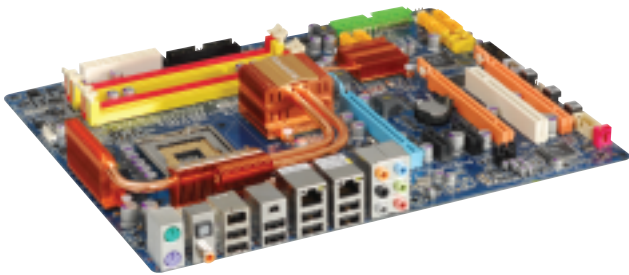
Gigabyte's EP45 is the next P45 board we've received for testing after the ASUS P5Q in the June issue. It makes use of an ICH10R south bridge.

The board layout is free of all hassles. The fins are of better quality and are sturdier than we've seen in some of the older Gigabyte boards. There is good heat transfer between the two heat pipes, and the parts of the board don't really get too hot. The SATA connectors are lower beyond the PCI-E slot so there is no problem of cables coming in the way of long cards. The board supports up to 16 GB of DDR2 1200 MHz memory and also has two gigabit network adapters onboard. There are buttons on the board for power, reset

and clearing CMOS, and they're clearly visible.

In terms of performance, once again there is little to report. Other than miniscule changes here and there, there's nothing that makes this or any other P45 board stand out. The only places there are some changes are in the video encoding. The Gigabyte P45 did it some two seconds faster than the P35 of last year. PC Mark 2005 was 8557 as compared to 8485 of the Abit IP35-Pro. 3DMarks score was also up by some 200 points.

All the features found on some of the higher-end Gigabyte boards are present including Gigabyte's power saving technology—DES. The board only comes with a single PCI slot which means



if you attach an additional sound card, there isn't any space for a wireless LAN card for example.

The Gigabyte P45 board is great and there is really nothing wrong with it but the price. At Rs 17,890, it is quite a lot for a board like this. Other than the similar cooling solutions, ASUS' P5Q comes with the unique ExpressGate feature. If it is to be compared with the P5Q-E, that is a better value for money product than the EP45-DS4P.

Specifications
LGA775 socket, Supports 45-nm

processors, System bus: 800 / 1066 / 1333 / 1600 MHz, Maximum RAM supported: 16 GB DDR2 1200 MHz, ATI CrossFireX support, ATX form factor.

Contact
GIGABYTE Technology India Ltd
Phone: +91-22-40633222
E-mail: vivek@gigabyte.in
Web site: www.gigabyte.com.tw
Price: Rs 17,890

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Iomega ScreenPlay HD 500GB

An external hard drive with playback capability

External drives are great for lugging media around but what if these drives could play it as well—the Iomega ScreenPlay HD happens to do just that. The one we have is a 500 GB version.

The drive is housed in a sturdy abrasive finished monocoque. It can be used as a portable drive too. The device connects like any other external drive using USB. Transfers don't take long and on an average, 20MBps is easily achievable. External power using a power adapter is required to power the device.

Installation is simple and there is support for HDMI which makes the setting up part even simpler. No HDMI cables are provided though.

The user interface is



rather disappointing and it looks pretty outdated. The icons and cli-

codecs with some of the HD content we played on it. Standard DivX and XviD files give no such problem. Audio formats were no problem either. The player upscales video to 720p and 1080i. At 1080i there was severe flickering. Loading images is painfully slow at times. Even changing settings requires one to stop all media viewing and returning back to the main menu.

A typical external 3.5-inch hard drive setup would cost anyone somewhere around Rs 5,000. The Iomega ScreenPlay HD 500GB is priced at Rs 10,000. It is still cheaper and simpler to use the ScreenPlay HD than it is to set up a full fledged HTPC. For just additional media playback feature, this is an

excessively costly product. If it were priced at say Rs 7,000, it would be perfect and worth every penny.

Specifications
500GB drive, USB 2.0 interface, HDMI support, Supports MP3, AC3, WMA, WAV, OGG, MPEG1, MPEG2, MPEG4, JPEG. Dimensions: 12.7 x 5.8 x 19.6 cm

Contact:
Neoteric Informatique Ltd.
Phone: +91-22-40859600
E-mail: sales@neoteric.co.in
Web site: www.neoteric.co.in
Price: Rs 10,000

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
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Dell XPS 730

A heavyweight with awkward proportions



With a lot of people depending on systems assemblers to build their systems, the better known branded PC market seems to be dipping. Dell is determined to show their presence and they've gathered up their resources, built a system and have delivered it to our test centre—the Dell XPS 730.

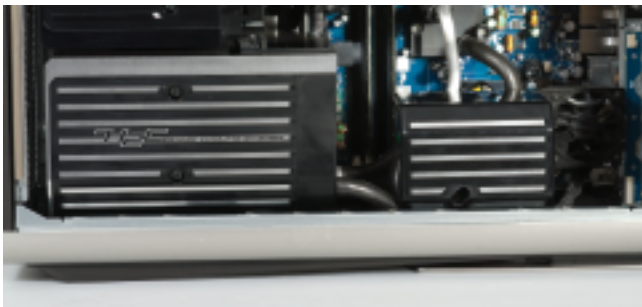
The XPS 730 is a beast and it sure weighs like one. The case is one of the largest we've seen. It towers to around the same height as a Coolermaster stacker or the Cosmos and is built really well—thick metal, a fine and attractive finish

and design to top it off. There are flashy bits with multiple little led-like lights staring down from the front border of the case. The same design is at the rear of the case near the connectors—useful while reaching out to the rear of the case and connecting cables and other devices.

The hardware components put into the system are not the latest but still very impressive. The Intel Core 2 Quad Q9300 running at 2.5 GHz. There is 4 GB of DDR3 from the 2 memory sticks. There are some shocking things about the 730 as well. The big one undoubtedly is

to do with the motherboard and the graphics card. This system runs on what is most likely a NVIDIA 790i board running two 3870X2s in CrossFire which is very unheard of! Dell has taken it one step ahead and set up a humongous water cooling kit at the bottom of the case. For all these power requirements, an equally power supply of mammoth proportions is used.

The customizations are on the inside as well. The power supply lies at the top of the case and the drives lie in between it and the cards and motherboard below. The space where the hard drives would usually lie now is taken up by the cooler.



The massive water cooling unit

All this hardware adds up to some good performance but definitely not the best. The power of the two cards coupled together allow it match and sometimes outperform the GTX 280. Prey at 1600 x 1200 at maximum quality and 4x antialiasing and 8x anisotropic filtering can easily run at 185 fps. The small 320 GB Seagate Barracuda 7200.10 drive recorded 85MB/s rates on SiSoft Sandra. The memory benchmarks were far more impressive because of the DDR3 memory.

A rather standard 22-inch E228WFP from Dell is supplied. You get a Dell keyboard and mouse similar to what we've seen from previous Dell systems.

The package is complete with a file to hold your discs and the thick user manuals.

At Rs 1,39,000, it's overly expensive to even consider. A similar setup could be built for a much cheaper price but the case and the water cooling are what make it special.

The Dell XPS 730 is a mighty rig and easily one of the fastest readymade systems anyone can buy in the market, but one gets the feeling it isn't the best they could do. The water cooling for example would make better sense if used on the graphics cards than on just the processor and the north-bridge. A much larger hard

The colourful interiors of the XPS 730 exposed



Specifications
Intel Core 2 Quad Q9300, 4 GB DDR3 RAM, ATI Radeon 3870x2, 22-inch Dell E228WFP LCD, 320 GB Seagate Barracuda 7200.10.

Contact: Dell
Phone: 1800- 425- 4026
E-mail: Online_India@dell.com
Web site: www.dell.com
Price: Rs 1,39,900

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
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